

THE CULT OF KHALI

From action figure to part-time movie star, Dalip Singh Rana's WWE alter ego has become a one-man spectacle. He may not be the wrestling circus's biggest champion, but he is their biggest clown.

■ By Ramesh Vinayak
and Kaveree Bamzai

If World Wrestling Entertainment (WWE) is Middle America's biggest joke on humanity, then The Great Khali is its biggest joker. With an Arabian-themed entrance tune matching his waddle, a name plucked from Amrish Puri's Kali-worshipping weirdo in Steven Spielberg's *Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom*, and "Punjabi peace offerings" ranging from Ganga water to a goat, the 36-year-old is one of the star entertainers in a circus of vicious looking men with names like Umaga and Undertaker contesting in fervid face-offs called Raw and Smackdown. It's a status that has little to do with performance—since joining WWE in 2006, the Punjab Police sub-inspector on permanent medical-leave has been world heavyweight champion just once, after winning a 20-man battle last year.

But that hasn't prevented the boy who grew too much from getting a hero's welcome back home, fuelled by head-of-state-worthy coverage by hyperventilating news channels. Dalip Singh Rana (yes, he is actually a former labourer from Himachal Pradesh) has suddenly become India's most wanted guest—having a tete-a-tete with President Pratibha Patil, chatting with Sachin Tendulkar, Shweta Nanda and Robert Vadra's children, and being invited for dinner to Shah Rukh Khan's house at 2 a.m. His iconic status in his home state is now assured. A special grant has been sanctioned from the MPLADS scheme to build a road to his native village, Naini Dhar, a hamlet of two-dozen houses in the interiors of Sirmour district, while Chief Minister Prem Kumar Dhumal has announced plans to felicitate the "son-of-the soil" at a special function. Even the Punjab



ANINDITO MUKHERJEE

TALL ORDER: Khali and Harminder (right)